

Ethics Policy

Institute of Minecraft Studies Publishing Department

I General provisions

1. § This ethics policy applies to authors, reviewers, and all members of the Department.
2. § Fundamental values of the Department are honesty, reliability, fairness, objectivity, accuracy, transparency, accessibility, independence, impartiality, open communication, duty of care, and responsibility.
3. § Authors are responsible for their works, including accuracy, originality, permissions, consent, and proper citation.
4. § All research should be designed and carried out in a careful and well-considered manner. Negligence, haste, carelessness, and inattention should be avoided, so as to prevent human errors.
5. § The full results of trials and experiments must be published, subject to ethical, legal, and practical limits.
6. § Plagiarism, fabrication, falsification, deception, and behavior contrary to the values of the Institution or of the Department are unacceptable.
7. § Works may not be judged based on the author's reputation, status, popularity, previous work, or personal ties. Works, edits, and reviews must only focus on the content itself, not the person.
8. § Usernames, personal information, and any other sensitive data must be properly handled and redacted, unless explicit, informed consent can be shown (minors cannot consent).

II Conflicts of interest and AI use

9. § Conflict of interest (COI) includes any competing interest, relationship, or role that could affect judgment. Authors, editors, and reviewers must recuse in cases of a major COI, materially affecting impartiality.

10. § Usage of AI (such as LLMs, chatbots, generative AI) must be properly disclosed, including exact model versions, prompts, and responses or (if the editor allows it) a description of how it was used. Submitted works must be original.

11. § Authors, editors, and reviewers must disclose any relevant COI and AI usage to the readership.

12. § The editor decides whether a COI or AI usage warrants a rejection of article or peer review. The relevant coordinator decides whether an editor's COI or AI usage warrants recusal.

III Appeals

13. § Appeals may be submitted regarding decisions made by one person (e.g., rejecting an article).

14. § Appealed actions can be sustained, overruled, or struck down. Appeals are handled and ruled on by the coordinator of the relevant subdepartment. Their decisions and rulings can be appealed to the editor-in-chief. In unclear cases, the coordinator/editor-in-chief should ask for the staff's opinion. The editor-in-chief's decisions and rulings can be appealed to the Department.

IV Complaints

IV.1 Submitting complaints

15. § Complaints of misconduct or unfair treatment are to be reported to the coordinator of the relevant subdepartment, the editor-in-chief, or an IMS admin. Frivolous complaints are rejected.

16. § Concerns about suspected misconduct must be reported. Good-faith reporters must not be retaliated against.

IV.2 Investigations

17. § Investigations are fair, speedy, and are carried through to a conclusion (regardless of the subject leaving), ensuring accuracy, objectivity, and thoroughness. People accused are guaranteed due process. Investigations are conducted with appropriate confidentiality so as to allow whistleblowing. Everyone must reasonably cooperate with the investigation.

18. § Complaints are investigated jointly by the coordinator and the editor-in-chief. The deadline of presenting their report to the Department is 30 days after receiving the complaint.

IV.3 Investigations by a committee

19. § Investigation is performed instead by a committee if

- (1) the coordinator or the editor-in-chief is the subject of the complaint,
- (2) the coordinator or the editor-in-chief requests so,
- (3) the complaint details a systematic issue or an issue spanning multiple subdepartments,
- (4) the coordinator and editor-in-chief cannot come to agreement,
- (5) the report is not presented to the Department by the deadline, or
- (6) the Department finds the report to be inadequate.

20. § Complainants and the subjects of complaints cannot be committee members. The six members of the committee are (in this order): the editor-in-chief, subdepartment coordinators, IMS admins, and elected IMS members. Committee members disclose their COI. The committee makes decisions by a majority vote of all members.

21. § The committee may impose temporary injunctions if needed.

22. § The deadline of presenting the report to the Department is 30 days after the formation of the committee, but the committee may extend this deadline up to 90 days after formation. If the committee fails to present its

report by the deadline, the committee is disbanded and a new committee consisting of six elected IMS members investigates instead.

IV.4 Reports

23. § Investigations end with a report containing findings of fact and recommended actions. The Department reviews this report and votes on its recommended actions and other proposed remedies (subjects of complaints don't vote). These reports are made public to IMS members (with appropriate redactions).

24. § When deciding the appropriate remedies, the severity, intent, and impact of the violation must be taken into consideration, and the judgement must be

- (1) fair to IMS members, by protecting them from unethical conduct, while also not denying them from the offender's contributions;
- (2) fair to the offender; and
- (3) severe enough to serve as a deterrent.

25. § All confirmed breaches are addressed proportionately through appropriate action. As integrity is one of our core values, the Department must be vigilant for any and all cases of misconduct.